

BUDGET HEARING NOTES

Tuesday, May 18, 2021 7:00 PM

Via Zoom

The agenda will be as follows:

- Discussion of the development of the operating budget and budgetary priorities of the Medford Public Schools for Fiscal Year 2022 (July 1, 2021 - June 30, 2022) as it pertains specifically to academic content areas including Math, English Learners, Athletics and Technology/Libraries.

7:03: Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn read opening remarks.

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn - 7 present, 0 absent

Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent: Intro.

Dave Murphy: Tonight is the Academic Programming Session Two. Right now we are in the phase of presenting the superintendent's recommendations. Funding from the operating budget traditionally comes from Chapter 70 from the state and the municipal portion from the city as well as grants. This year we added a column for federal dollars contributing COVID 19 funding.

- Personnel
- Materials or Infrastructure
- Professional Development

Each director was asked to address each of these areas in order to provide as much remedial support as possible

As we said as far back as April 26, knowing there are restrictions of the ESSER funding, not wanting to create fiscal deficits, and the nature of the CBAs that are up this year: lots of unanswered questions. Projections are \$3.4 - \$5.8 increase. Numbers are fluid. Esser funds (II and III) are \$7.6m for next year.

Long term budget priorities are not being addressed during these meetings. They are not being incorporated into the operating budget for FY22. We want the community to know about it but know that the range would not cover these.

Faiza Khan:

Restoration of Math interventionist positions at McGlynn and Andrews Middle Schools.

I have been reaching out to other districts about mitigating gaps created by Covid19. Most

places have put these in place through ESSER funding or through other means. They work with identified small groups. Trained interventionists with lots of PD who know how to identify the gaps. Can apply strategies to students: right help at the right time. I personally believe that these two positions will play an important role in bringing equity in Math to our students.

In elementary we have been using Envisions 2015 but it was up for renewal last June 2020. We are in the process of looking at different programs by different publishers. It seems imperative that we will be reviewing Envisions for one more year at the same time as we pilot programs at other elementary schools. Last year we used the online version of Envisions 2020 free of charge. Envisions 2020 online version is a better way to go than Envisions 2015 which is so outdated that it cannot be offered in its full capacity. We will move forward with renewing the Envisions 2020 version. We will get the paper version this year. I will then take a close look at it to make sure it is aligned with the standards.

Summer program in development/extended school day initiatives.

Basic gaps can be filled via smaller projects/in person games/hands on activities. I am hoping to have a week long four hour a day Grade 6 -12 Math academy - engaging activities. Illustrative Mathematics and Engage New York as need be.

Extended school day support K-8.

Paul Teixeira: We used \$5k of CaresAct money to test Imagine Learning (Adaptive Literacy program for EL learners that uses formative assessment data along the way). I am looking to expand it to use with levels 3 and 4 students. We have Lexia for grades k, 1, 2, 3, and 4. In terms of staffing, I remain level funded. We added a position last year. The numbers at the high school continue to grow. Things might change in the next year but I believe we are adequately staffed. Additional expenses, I would like to restore the textbook budget to adapt to changes in History curriculum.

Technology: Molly Laden (instructional tech) and Alan Arena (operational technology/network infrastructure): Large portion will be pursued as capital improvement priorities. Technological deferred maintenance.

Instructional side: need to look at specific technologies that were not beneficial purchases through the care act funding last year. Projectors were the piece we didn't get to in FY21. If we are going to address the projector issue, is there a better solution.

Molly Laden: Smart Panels might be a solution. We are looking to the times when students are back in classrooms and libraries are open, we are looking to keep libraries open longer (before and after school) so we will need more paraprofessional support there. We are in a continuous cycle of replacing projectors and projector bulbs. We are hitting the end of life for many of them. Rather than replacing them at \$600/\$1000 a pop, we are looking at Smart Panels which are a more current technology. We are well endowed with many devices. We have Windows 7 2012 desktops that we need to replace or get rid of. We have a need for website support but we

don't have a webmaster. We need to maintain the site and secure it. As we have increased our technology, we have increased needs for tech support. As we have one to one devices, webcams, etc. we have to support them. We could use additional technical support. We have two technology teaching labs that have not been updated since 2012. Columbus and Brooks need to be updated to meet the needs of the projects the students are doing. The extended school day program is another initiative.

Alan Arena: Necessity of securing our network and provide archiving service. In addition to subscription services, most of the network is run by virtual servers. Unfortunately because of the age of the devices, we are past the mean time of failure. We can no longer get replacement parts or support for these devices. We are doing backups now with independent devices but we need to back up data and servers for emergency outages.

Dave Murphy: There will be more discussion of this as we talk about capital priorities.

Athletics: Bobby Maloney: Athletics are a means of student engagement. Unified Champion sports program a method of deepening student engagement through athletics. Spring season started today. Rachel Perry and I would like to add unified games to our athletic arena. We would like to add programs for our special needs population. Now is the time to pull the trigger on it. We are looking at approval from SC and the MIAA to get this off the ground in September. Thanks to Toni Wray and our trainer.

Questions:

Mea Mustone: for transportation, Bobby Maloney talked about Late buses and Mr. Texeira talked about the late bus for the EL programs.

Dave Murphy: There are line items within each academic area calling for transportation but there will be a specific transportation line when we present the operations budget tomorrow. Sports, band and EL have lines allocated to transportation. We are looking at a very comprehensive approach to extended day and summer programming. This will evolve over time because it is still being developed. It will carry into the start of next year's school year.

Kathy Kreatz: Do you have a week picked out for the Math academy.

Dave Murphy: We are going to have a multi-tiered approach to summer programming. We need to list the positions for the camps.

Kathy Kreatz; Do you have an update for Web support? Is there an opportunity for the CTE students to work after school?

Dave Murphy: Diane Caldwell has been working part time to convene a working group on our

website. She is working with Lisa Miller from MVTHS and they will be recruiting students to help and to also figure out what consulting support we need.

Paul Ruseau: We have no math interventionists in the elementary schools today?

Faiza Khan: That is right.

Paul Ruseau: A lot of these priorities that are expensive that we are putting way into the future. Do you think we will have more money in the future than now? Long time priorities are things we know we need but we know we are not going to get. Up until this meeting, I was understanding that the long term budget priorities were being included in this proposal.

Paul Ruseau: The EL item in the long term budget priorities seems very aligned with the student opportunity act. This seems like a surprising thing to put on the get to it in the future list. Support orientation practices of EL students is a critical item.

Dave Murphy: This connects with your initial question of does it fall into the longterm priority? The math coaching positions are positions that we are organizationally set up to take advantage of. They will be helpful when we are ready but not yet. We need to identify the deficiencies over time. There are other things that are beyond our financial capacity - if we get to year two of ESSER and we identify pieces in year one that weren't necessary that we can address in FY 23. There are other things where we have the concept but we don't know what it looks like in this moment. How do we advance the objective through other budgetary priorities.

We are redesigning a position in central office focused on family engagement. We are looking at addressing the EL objective but it doesn't lie in the EL budget.

Paul Ruseau: How are not the math coaches useful positions?

Dave Murphy; Will be helpful in building capacity in the future.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Question regarding Math, I heard transportation for after school. Will transportation be available for summer programs? In person or zoom?

Dave Murphy: With regards to transportation, we don't know the answer yet. The question is more whether there will be a demand for it. ESSER funding should fund it. When and where and who has not been ironed out yet. With regards to remote piece, we want it open to everyone. We want to reacclimate students to in person but we want to make the opportunities fully accessible so we will leave that lane open as well.

Melanie McLaughlin : I appreciate the cohesiveness around diversity and inclusion from each

department. In regards to the EL program, I look to Paul T. for leadership. Adaptive Literacy is a program that can be used in other departments as well. Universal design for learning crosses department boundaries. We can look at what the EL department is doing to assess improve literacy. Cultural competency needed in every department as well. In the tech department, I would like to hear more about accessibility for students with different learning needs. What is being offered to the community for assistive technology and adaptive technology. What training is provided for families?

Molly Laden: Ms. Bowen can answer a bit more than I can. As far as the tech that was purchased and rolled out, my dept. Handled. The decisions about what to buy is more Joan Bowen's area.

Melanie McLaughlin : I am looking at how it was implemented. Big picture how are you looking at it?

Joan Bowen: We do assistive technology needs assessments for each student. Molly and Jan Hollenbeck collaborate on what the best devices to purchase will be.

Melanie McLaughlin: Grace has access to BookShare. Anybody with a reading disability has access to Book Share (free books). I feel that people should know that to families throughout the district. I want to make sure that these resources are available across the board. Having the family engagement position will really help with these projects. We need a grant writer in the district.

Dave Murphy: Thank you for recognizing our attempt to present the budget in a cohesive fashion. We have tried to frame our questions and priorities to address systemic inequities reflected in your comments. The real work is how do we execute in a way that is reflective of the practice. We are positioning a central office to be a grant coordinator position.

Jenny Graham: I think we heard that we were not going to continue evaluating the math curriculums.

Faiza Khan: Only for the teachers not piloting the different programs.

Jenny Graham: Why no interventionists at the elementary level?

Dave Murphy: Elementary interventionists would be helpful. Prioritizing literacy intervention first. In terms of mapping out where we are, our current recommendation is to focus on literacy.

Superintendent Edouard-Vincent: In response to Jenny Graham's comment, it is a slightly different structure between elementary and middle. With us piloting math curricula in each building, the coaching and intervention should wait until the curriculum is set. We want to also align with Illustrative math which is being used at the middle school level. Hoping to have

literacy support at the elementary level.

Jenny Graham: In what year will we see math coaches and intervention at the Elementary schools?

Suzanne Galusi: Coaching is working with the staff. Interventionists would be pulling the students out of a math lesson and would miss the lesson. Scheduling and structural piece is the issue. We have to build up the structure to have push in interventionists.

Jenny Graham: The number on slides is \$255 - what thing is not on the slide?

Dave Murphy: I believe we were not adding in the math interventionists at the middle school. Full document says \$320 because it includes funding on those positions.

Jenny Graham: I want to be clear on what we will vote on tonight? Previously we included the long term priorities.

Dave Murphy: We understand the vote is the SC saying that they want to see projects funded.

Jenny Graham: We have a deficient curriculum, we have students behind....how do we not need additional staff? Always need coaching to help bring in new curriculum. I am not comfortable with zero.

Dave Murphy: We are grateful for the support but if we look to provide one coach, we will probably need to take other things out.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Ms. Khan, which grade levels are piloting and which are staying with Envisions 2020?

Faiza Khan: We have a committee made up of a variety of staff. Two programs will be selected at each school. It will not be that 3d grade all across will be piloting. Shooting for 4 at each grade level to be piloting (including newcomers and special education - 24 classrooms total will be piloting).

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Arbor funding. Broadband infrastructure. Do you have any idea as to how to fix the high school infrastructure.

Alan Arena: We are well undersubscribed at the high school level. We are not running out because of congestion on the line. Using less than 50%. If there are issues, it is at the device level not running out of bandwidth.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: As for parents reaching out saying that the students are staying home because the teachers are teaching remotely.

Alan Arena: If you have a number of students trying to stream video or audio at the same time. We are addressing that as we go through because it can be an individual basis. We have not found too many issues that we can't handle once we get access to the device.

Dave Murphy: We have made improvements with WIFI capacity. We need easier accessibility at various points. We may not have fleshed out all entry points. Priority has been to keep the network secure. Structure is in place. We just need to improve the systems. Key priority for the next year.

Paul Ruseau: Do we have promises for all items listed under capital improvements? Some of these things cannot wait.

Dave Murphy: We have a capital budget that we are working with. We have some capacity. There are competing demands. IE; roofing, hot water heaters, generators. There are a few things we can defer on and others are critical. Is the full list paid for? No. There are more demands than there is financial capacity.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Mr. Murphy and Superintendent Edouard-Vincent have taken all the guidance they can about ESSER money - we are doing the same on the city side with Arbor money. There are still lots of restrictions on the funding. We are looking to free up money to spend on the school side. We are hiring a consultant to guide us through this. Guidance just released last week. I am trying to get more money - just waiting for answers.

Paul Ruseau: I am surprised to not see spending on a municipal information system, a new website. That is not a website. I created this in 1995 in my senior class. We should be outsourcing this work to get it up and running. There are countless firms doing this for school systems. Surprised that our plan is to get a part time webmaster? Not going to solve the problem.

Dave Murphy: There is broad agreement that the website needs to function differently. The committee can decide where they want to place the priority. There is urgency. Budget priorities are reflection on what has to be done for students. I know the website is embarrassing and is frustrating for families. I don't think it rises to the same level as other items for students. You have the right to prioritize it. I feel there are other items needing more priority. The utility of websites has evolved. We may want a simpler website that drives users elsewhere to Social Media and other resources.

Paul Ruseau: One more technology question, how many full time staff members are in place to help with tech needs? When you are at the Columbus, and no one is there, what is the

turnaround time?

Molly Laden: Two full time support personnel right now and we are looking to add one more. We have a google admin. Our library staff have also been doing tech support. There are people in every building because of library staff. We were incredibly short staffed this year and our tech teachers and librarians have stepped up incredibly well this year. We have done pretty well all things considered but our librarians need to go back to being librarians.

Paul Ruseau: We have technology security practices that are pretty distressing. I have never changed my password since joining Medford School Community. Do we have anybody or a group working on fixing glaring holes in security.

Dave Murphy: looking to address this and we are addressing some things behind the scenes. I would like to share it further out because we have a lot backed up in executive session.

Jenny Graham: Regarding the instructional tech narrative, I think there is a typo in elementary librarian staff.

Molly Laden: Yes there is an error in that staffing?

Jenny Graham: Is there no plan to increase librarian support in the district. We have a half time position to cover 1000 elementary students. The paraprofessionals are not supposed to take those reins. Massive understaffing in that space. Surprised we are not asking for more.

Also want to point out that I am not in support of paying people to do work, leading a working group on the website. It is an art and a trade unto itself. I want to pay the district's money wisely. The district cannot make decisions of the website without engaging the users. Strategic plan supposed to address communication. Look forward to seeing the job description for a family engagement person. Need to look outside the organization professionally speaking. Not look to shuffle people around to give people new titles. There is a long way to go with communication.

My understanding was we had to move MCAS at the high school due to an internet issue. If capital issues are funding, will we not have these issues in the future.

Dave Murphy: There is no security system that we can put in place to change the motives of students actively taking down the network. We will work to diminish the prospect of this disruption. We have to get to a better place.

Paul Ruseau; Point of information: are you saying that the disruption was an intentional act? Why weren't we notified?

Paul Ruseau: I would hope we can get an update at the next SC meeting.

Jenny Graham: Do we need other expertise as to the right path forward on this? Do other districts have to shut down due to hackers? What is the real plan we need to make the building viable, network viable, instruction viable? When do we find out about the capital funds that the school districts will receive?

Dave Murphy: There was approximately \$800k in capital funding and \$160K left over from science labs project. We are referring to these two pools of money. As to whether we have the internal expertise, they are mostly projects we will need to put projects out to bid. We do need outside expertise for these projects and are looking at that for the summer.

Jenny Graham: The Communication Subcommittee was completely unaware of the working group that doesn't include the school committee and the public.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Tomorrow we have another budget meeting at 7pm. Final hearing 6.1.2021.

Melanie McLaughlin: motion to adjourn the meeting.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I am happy to hear athletics will be back in the fall. I am excited to learn about the Unified sports program.

Seconded by Paulette Van der Kloot.

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn - Yes 7 affirmative 0 negative- meeting adjourned.